

[WORKSHOP] [SIDE-GUIDE] [€0 ROUTE]

FREE AGENT



SIDE GUIDE // AN AI CODING AGENT WITHOUT A SUBSCRIPTION

Want to try the workshop's editor and agent levels before paying for anything? This guide sets up a coding agent that costs nothing: **Kilo Code** or **Cline**, two open-source agents for VS Code, running free models through **OpenRouter**. It also covers Cursor's free plan and what it can and can't do.

C O S T	T I M E	N E E D S	U S E F O R
€0 - NO CARD	ABOUT 20 MIN	SECTION 00 DONE	LEVELS 2 + 3

PICK YOUR ROUTE

A KILO CODE

Recommended. Open-source agent for VS Code and the terminal. Free models via OpenRouter, or Kilo's own **Auto Free**.

SECTIONS 01 - 03

B CLINE

Open-source agent for VS Code with a **Plan / Act** switch that matches the workshop's "plan first" habit.

SECTIONS 01, 02, 04

C CURSOR HOBBY

A whole AI editor, free, with a small monthly allowance. Your own keys need a paid plan.

SECTION 05

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SECTION 01

WHAT "FREE" REALLY MEANS

READ THIS FIRST • 2 MIN

Free models are real, capable models, and they are enough to build the workshop's Weather Dashboard. They come with four trade-offs you should know before you start:

TRADE-OFF

WHAT IT MEANS FOR YOU

Daily limits

OpenRouter allows **20 requests a minute** and **50 requests a day** on free models. An agent uses several requests per task, so 50 goes quickly: plan your session. (Accounts that have ever bought \$10 of credit get 1,000 a day.)

Your prompts may be kept

Free providers may log prompts or use them for training. **Never** paste passwords, keys, customer data or company code into a free model.

Quality varies

Free models are usually smaller than paid ones. They follow a clear plan well and wander off on vague requests: the workshop habits matter even more.

The list changes

Free models come and go every few weeks. This guide uses routes that keep working when a model disappears.

SECTION 02

OPENROUTER ACCOUNT + KEY

ROUTES A + B • 5 MIN • ONCE

OpenRouter is one account that gives you access to hundreds of models, including free ones. If you already set it up for Level 2 in the handout, check step 02 and skip to your route.

- 01 Go to **openrouter.ai** and sign up (Google, GitHub or email). You don't need to add a card or buy credits.
- 02 Open **openrouter.ai/settings/privacy** and switch on the options that allow **free endpoints** that may train on or publish prompts. Without this, every free model answers with an error.

[WHY]

This is the price of "free": the providers can learn from what you send. That's why you keep secrets and work code out of it.

- 03 Open **openrouter.ai/settings/keys** → **Create API Key**. Name it workshop-free and set the **credit limit** to 0. Free models still work, and the key can never spend money even if you pick a paid model by mistake.
- 04 Copy the key (it starts with sk-or-). OpenRouter shows it only once: keep this tab open until your agent is set up.

[NOTE]

Treat the key like a password: paste it only into the tool's settings, never into a chat, a file in your project, or Git. If it leaks, delete it on the Keys page and make a new one.

SECTION 03

ROUTE A - KILO CODE

VS CODE + TERMINAL • 10 MIN • OPEN SOURCE AGENT

Kilo Code is a free, open-source coding agent that lives in the VS Code sidebar. Like the Level 3 agents, it can read your files, write changes and run commands, and it asks before it does anything.

3.1 INSTALL

- 01 Open your workshop folder in VS Code as in the handout (on Windows, the bottom-left corner shows **WSL: Ubuntu**).
- 02 Open Extensions (Ctrl+Shift+X), search **Kilo Code** and install the one by **Kilo Code**. A Kilo icon appears in the left activity bar.
- 03 Click the icon. If Kilo asks you to sign in, do so: a free Kilo account is fine, and it's what unlocks Auto Free (3.4).

3.2 CONNECT OPENROUTER

- 01 In the Kilo panel click the **gear icon** → **Settings** → **Providers**.
- 02 Choose **OpenRouter** and paste your sk-or- key.
- 03 For the model, type openrouter/free. It's OpenRouter's free router: each request goes to a free model that's online and supports what the agent needs, so it keeps working when individual models disappear.

3.3 FIRST CHECK

In the Kilo chat box, send:

PROMPT

List the files in this folder and tell me which model you are. Don't change anything.

[CHECK]

Kilo lists your files (it may ask permission to read them: allow it) and names a model. On **openrouter.ai/activity** the request shows up with a cost of **\$0**.

3.4 NO OPENROUTER? USE KILO AUTO FREE

In the Kilo model picker, choose **Auto Free**, or any model labelled **(free)**. Kilo routes the request to a free model for you: nothing else to set up. The same rules apply: providers may log what you send, so keep secrets out.

3.5 WANT A SPECIFIC MODEL?

On **openrouter.ai/models**, filter by **Free** and **Tools** (agents need tool calling), and prefer a large context window (128K or more). Copy the model ID, which ends in **:free**, into Kilo's model field (the same works in Cline). Names we have seen work well change monthly, so check the list rather than relying on a name from last month.

3.6 OPTIONAL: KILO IN THE TERMINAL (LEVEL 3 STYLE)

Kilo also has a command-line agent, the free equivalent of the Level 3 tools. It needs Node.js from Section 0.4 of the handout.

UBUNTU TERMINAL

```
npm install -g @kilocode/cli
cd ~/guided-coding/level3
kilo
```

In the session, type `/connect`, choose **OpenRouter** and paste your key, then `/models` to pick `openrouter/free` or a `:free` model. Kilo reads `AGENTS.md` just like the other Level 3 agents.

[NOTE]

Never use `sudo npm`. If you get `EACCES`, Node wasn't installed with `nvm`: redo step 0.4 of the handout.

3.7 SETTINGS WORTH CHANGING

SETTING	WHY
Auto-approve: off	Keep Kilo asking before it writes files or runs commands. Reading each request is part of learning, and it stops a confused free model from making a mess.
Autocomplete: off	Inline suggestions send a request every few keystrokes and eat the 50-a-day budget. Turn it off, or give it its own free Mistral (Codestral) key as Kilo's docs describe.
Small / background model: free	Kilo uses a second model to title and summarise chats. Point it at <code>openrouter/free</code> too, so nothing touches paid credits.

SECTION 04

ROUTE B - CLINE

VS CODE • 10 MIN • OPEN SOURCE AGENT

Cline is the open-source agent Kilo Code grew out of, and one of the Level 2 extensions the handout suggests. It works the same way, asking before it acts. Use your key from Section 02.

- 01
- In VS Code Extensions (`Ctrl+Shift+X`) install **Cline** by **Cline**. Open it from its icon in the left activity bar.
- 02
- If Cline offers to sign in to a Cline account, choose the option to **use your own API key** instead. Otherwise click the **gear icon** in the Cline panel.
- 03
- Set **API Provider** to **OpenRouter**, paste the key into **OpenRouter API Key**, and in **Model** type `openrouter/free` (or a `:free` model ID, see 3.5). Click **Done**, then send the first-check prompt from 3.3.

[PLAN / ACT]

Under the chat box is a **Plan / Act** switch. Start every task in **Plan**: Cline only reads and discusses. Switch to **Act** when you agree with the plan, and it starts editing. Leave auto-approve off, as for Kilo (3.7).

SECTION 05

ROUTE C - CURSOR HOBBY

A WHOLE AI EDITOR • FREE PLAN • NO CARD

Cursor is a copy of VS Code with AI built in. Its **Hobby** plan is free and doesn't expire, with a limited number of agent requests and Tab completions each month. It feels polished, but there's an important catch for this guide:

[CATCH]

On the free plan you can't use your own OpenRouter key. Bring-your-own-key needs Cursor Pro. On Hobby you use Cursor's built-in models (the **Auto** setting), within the free allowance.

- 01
- Download Cursor from **cursor.com**, install it and sign in (a free account; no card). It can import your VS Code extensions and settings on first start.
- 02
- On Windows, open your folder **inside WSL**, just as with VS Code: `Ctrl+Shift+P` → **WSL: Connect to WSL** (install the WSL extension if Cursor offers it), then **File** → **Open Folder** → `~/guided-coding`.
- 03
- Open the agent panel (`Ctrl+I`), leave the model on **Auto**, and send the first-check prompt from 3.3.

Tip: when the monthly Hobby allowance runs out, you can install the Kilo Code extension inside Cursor and carry on with route A or B. Cursor is a VS Code copy, so Sections 03 and 04 work unchanged.

5.1 WHICH ROUTE IS FOR ME?

	A • KILO CODE	B • CLINE	C • CURSOR HOBBY
Open source	Yes	Yes	No
Accounts	OpenRouter, or Kilo for Auto Free	OpenRouter	Cursor
You choose the model	Yes, any free one	Yes, any free one	No, Auto only
Limit	50 requests / day (OpenRouter)	50 requests / day (OpenRouter)	Monthly allowance
Terminal agent	Yes (Kilo CLI)	Editor only here	Not on this plan
Upgrade path	\$10 of OpenRouter credit: 1,000 free requests a day, plus paid models on the same key		Cursor Pro

SECTION 06

USING IT IN THE WORKSHOP

WHERE THE FREE AGENT FITS • HOW TO STRETCH 50 REQUESTS

LEVEL	WITH THE FREE SETUP
01 Web chat	Unchanged: any free chat account. Save your free agent's requests for later.
02 Editor + memory	Use Kilo or Cline instead of Copilot Chat. In Cline, Plan mode is the "plan before code" step. Keep PLAN.md and MEMORY.md exactly as the handout says, and mention them in your prompts: "Read PLAN.md and MEMORY.md first."
03 CLI agents	Use the Kilo CLI (3.6) with AGENTS.md and TASKS.md. Parallel agents and MCP servers still work, but each one spends from the same daily budget.

6.1 HABITS THAT SAVE REQUESTS

- 01 **Plan in one prompt.** Ask for the plan first ("no code yet"), fix it, then say "build step 1 only". A good plan costs one request; a vague start costs ten.
- 02 **One file at a time.** Small, checkable changes are exactly what smaller models do best.
- 03 **Paste the exact error.** The debugging loop from the handout (run → copy the exact error → paste it back → re-run) matters more with free models: the full message saves guessing.
- 04 **Start a new chat per task.** Long chats send the whole history every time, which is slower and confuses smaller models. MEMORY.md carries what matters.
- 05 **Stuck twice? Switch models.** If an answer loops or breaks twice, try a different :free model before rewording a third time.

6.2 WHEN TO PAY

If you use it most days and keep hitting the limits, the cheapest upgrade is a one-off **\$10 of OpenRouter credit**: free models go up to 1,000 requests a day, and you can try paid models on the same key. Raise the key's credit limit only as far as you're happy to spend.

SECTION B

IF IT BREAKS

KEEP THIS OPEN WHILE YOU WORK

YOU SEE

DO THIS

No endpoints found matching your data policy	The free-model privacy options are off. Redo step 02 in Section 02 (openrouter.ai/settings/privacy).
429 /Rate limit exceeded	More than 20 requests in a minute: wait a minute. If it says the daily limit, you've used today's 50: switch to Kilo Auto Free or Cursor, or carry on tomorrow.
401 /No auth credentials /User not found	The key is wrong or deleted. Make a new one (Section 02, step 03) and paste it again, with no spaces around it.
402 /Insufficient credits	The model you picked isn't free. Pick openrouter/free or an ID that ends in :free. Your credit limit of 0 did its job.
model not found /No endpoints found for ...:free	That free model has been retired. Use openrouter/free, or choose a new one from the Free filter (3.5).
Agent describes changes but never edits files, or says it can't use tools	The model doesn't support tool calling well. Switch to one with the Tools tag, or to openrouter/free.
Answers loop, repeat or stop halfway	Start a new chat, give a shorter task ("only backend/main.py"), or switch models.
Very slow replies	Free capacity is shared, so peak hours are slow. Wait, or try another free model.
Cursor: no field for my own key / "requires Pro"	Expected on Hobby (Section 05). Use Auto, or install Kilo or Cline inside Cursor.
kilo: command not found	Close and reopen the terminal. Check <code>node --version</code> works; if not, redo nvm (handout 0.4).

Limits, plans and menu names were checked in September 2026 and change often. Always trust what the tool shows you over this sheet: [openrouter.ai/docs](#) · [kilo.ai/docs](#) · [docs.cline.bot](#) · [cursor.com/pricing](#).